From Review to Remediation: Building a Sustainable Reparative Metadata Workflow



LIBRARIES

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Pilot

April 2025 to August 2026

Library of Congress Subject Headings:

- Illegal immigration
- Problem children
- Sexual minorities
- McKinley, Mount (Alaska)
- America, Gulf of

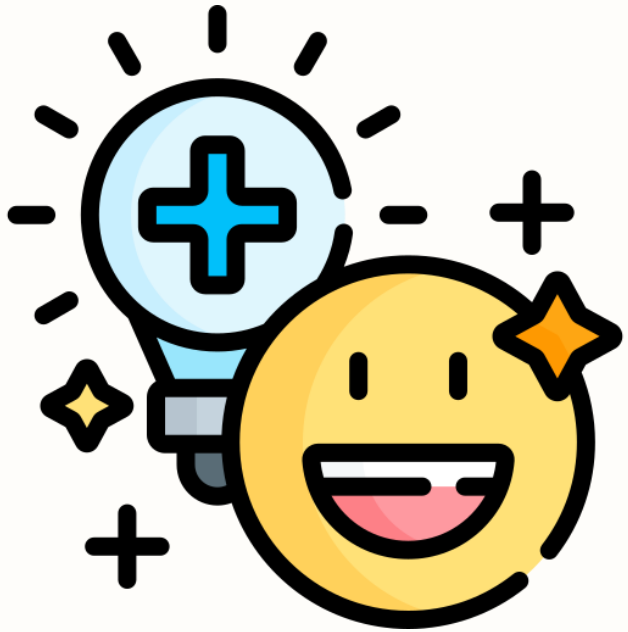


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Goal

Develop practices to replace or supplement pejorative or outdated terms in our metadata

Engage stakeholders early and often
Build sustainable, documented processes
Leverage native Alma and Primo tools
Apply changes consortium-wide
Design every change to be reversible



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Getting started

Other library work as inspiration

University of Toronto:
Indigenous Metadata Work

Washington Research Library Consortium:
Reparative Cataloging CoP



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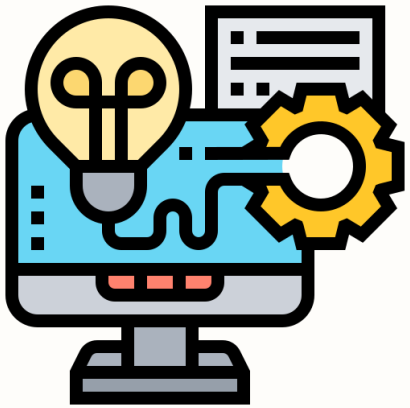
Research

Ask…

What do people call themselves?
What's respectful?
What's current?
What do other libraries use?
Who should we ask?
Replace, supplement, or keep?

Find…

Testimonials
Affinity groups
Committee publications
Peer libraries
News and journal articles



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Recommend

Identify action to propose

- Replace
- Conditional
- Supplement
- Retain



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Rationale examples 1 & 2

Although these terms refer to the broad group of people who enter or remain in a country without legal authorization, the use of "Illegal," "unauthorized," and "undocumented" imply different connotations and perspectives. Not all immigration starts out as illegal activity. UNL Libraries considers "Undocumented immigration" a more respectful and neutral term to use.

The Library of Congress decided to replace the pejorative "Illegal aliens" heading with a complex solution, two tandem headings, "Noncitizens" and "Illegal immigration." When the immigration heading is present on records with headings containing "Noncitizens" (or many related variations), UNL Libraries will change the heading to use "Undocumented immigrants" instead.

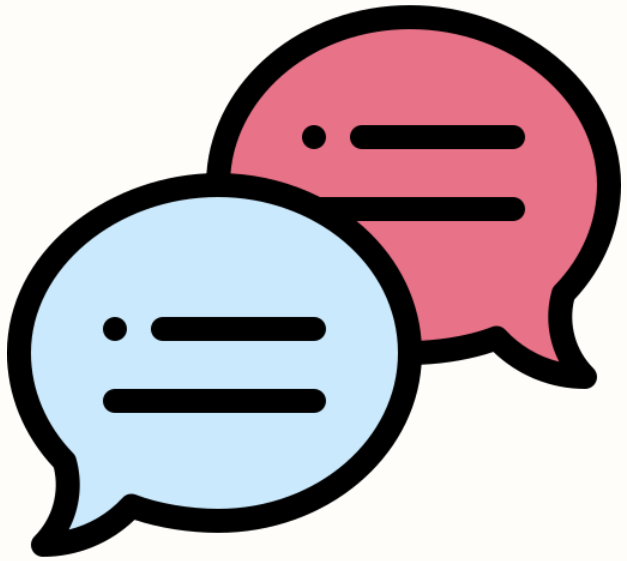
Rationale example 3

Library of Congress and the US Geological Survey (USGS) changed this term due to the signing of Executive Order 14172. As a US institution, it serves our users for our records to be consistent with the geographic names used by government agencies. However, there is an opportunity for confusion and a chance that resources become less discoverable for users who are unaware of the name change or its impact to LCSH. There has also been tension in both public and library discourse surrounding the reasons for the name change and the cultural impacts of the change. UNL Libraries will supplement records with both names.

Stakeholders

We asked before we changed

Shared every proposal before implementation
Engaged Libraries staff, groups, and consortium members
Consulted communities and subject experts
Adapted when feedback called for it

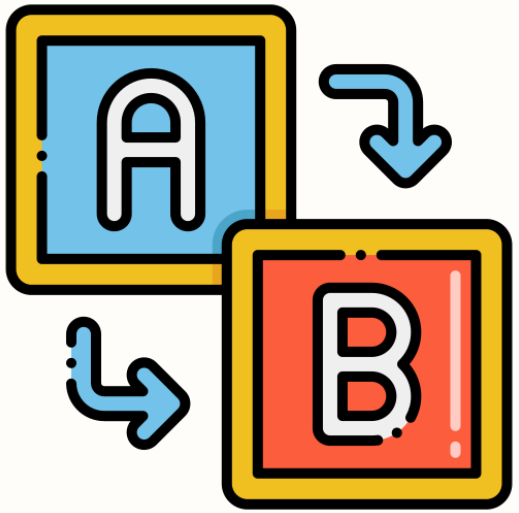


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Making the change

At this point:

- ✓ Identified term needing reparative work
- ✓ Chose replacement/supplemental term
- ✓ Determined an action (replace, supplement, etc.)
- ✓ Gathered feedback from stakeholders



Choose the technical approach that best suits the desired action. Every approach is easily reversible!

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Local Authority Records

A quick and simple way to make direct 1:1 changes

- Derived from existing LCSH records
- Added field to include rationale for the change
- Alma's Preferred Term Correction job automatically changes the subject headings
- Used for Illegal immigration, Sexual minorities, and Problem children

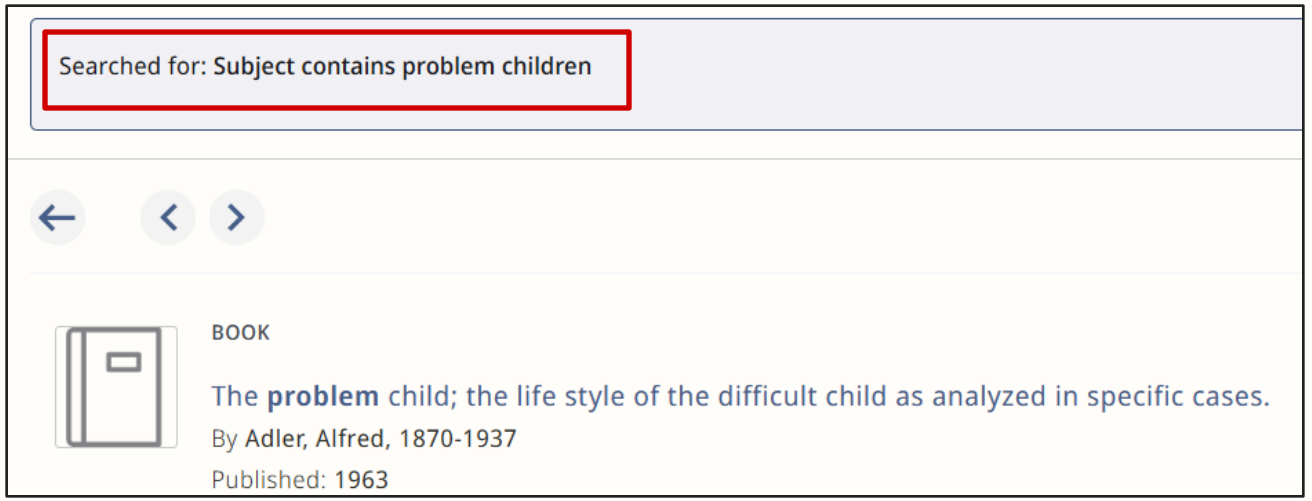


Authority free icon created by Flat Icons - Flaticon

010	__ |a sh 85107104
035	__ |a (DLC) sh 85107104
035	__ |a (LIBRARY_OF_CONGRESS)98170919900000041
040	__ |a DLC |c DLC |d DLC |d ViU
150	__ |a Children with behavioral problems
450	__ |a Problem children |5 NbU
450	__ |a Difficult children
450	__ |a Maladjusted children
550	__ |w g |a Children
550	__ |a Behavior disorders in children
667	__ |a “Problem children” is a term that was used in educational and psychological literature to describe children with behavior issues due to emotional instability or social environment. The literature has shifted to focus on the behavior rather than the nature of the children, making this term outdated. Current headings found in relevant databases include "behavior problems" and "problem behavior." UNL Libraries considers “Children with behavioral problems” to be a more respectful and neutral term and that it maintains parity with the terminology currently found in the relevant psychological and educational literature databases.
670	__ |a Difficult children, there is no such thing, c2003: |b t.p. introd. (children demonstrating behavioral disorders are being classified as educationally difficult to manage)
680	__ |i Here are entered works on children with behavior difficulties due to emotional instability or social environment.

Details

Title	The **problem** child; the life style of the difficult child as analyzed in specific cases.
Creator	Adler, Alfred, 1870-1937
Publisher	New York Capricorn Books
Creation Date	1963
Format	xvii, 172 p. 21 cm
Note	"The present volume was published in German in 1930, as one of the volumes on Die Technik der Individualpsychologie ... and bore the subtitle Die Seele des schwererziehbaren Schulkindes."
Subject	**Children with behavioral problems**
Series	A Capricorn giant original, 228
Source	Library Catalog



https://unl.primo.exlibrisgroup.com/permalink/01UON_LINC/4occt9/alma9910176187397063 87

Normalization Rules

Some LCSH have multiple meanings or contexts that make a direct one-to-one change unsuitable.

- Normalization rules can change context-specific subject headings
- Used for the subject headings "Noncitizens" only when it appeared in records alongside "Illegal immigration"
- Rule is applied quarterly to catch newly added records

```
rule "Change 650.a Noncitizens to 650.a Undocumented immigrants when appearing with 650.a Illegal immigration"
when
   (exists "650.a.Noncitizens*") and (exists "650.a.Undocumented immigration*|Illegal immigration*")
then
   replaceContents "650.a.Noncitizens" with "Undocumented immigrants"
end
```

Details

Title	Alien smuggling : management and operational improvements needed to address growing problem : report to congressional committees
Creator	United States. General Accounting Office
Publisher	Washington, D.C. P.O. Box 37050, Washington, D.C. 20013 : The Office
Creation Date	2000
Format	35 p. : ill. ; 28 cm
Note	Cover title "May 2000." "GAO/GGD-00-103." "B-283952"--P. 1
Subject	**Undocumented immigrants** -- Government policy -- United States Smuggling -- United States -- Prevention **Undocumented immigration** -- Government policy -- United States **Undocumented immigrants**
Genre	Electronic books
Source	Library Catalog

https://unl.primo.exlibrisgroup.com/permalink/01UON_LINC/4occt9/alma991005416739706387

Normalization Rules

In some cases, we deemed it appropriate to supplement LCSH rather than replace them.

- Normalization rules added our supplemental headings in records that had specific LCSH
- This approach was used for the LCSH "America, Gulf of" and "McKinley, Mount (Alaska)" to support discoverability
- Added subject term in a local subject field (690)

```
rule "Add 690.a.Denali, Mount (Alaska), Gulf of when 651.a.McKinley, Mount (Alaska)*"
when
   (exists "651.a.McKinley, Mount (Alaska)*")
then
   addField "690.a.Denali, Mount (Alaska)" if (not exists "690.a.Denali, Mount (Alaska)*")
   addSubfield "690.5.NbU" if (exists "690.a.Denali, Mount (Alaska)")
   addSubfield "690.9.local" if (exists "690.a.Denali, Mount (Alaska)")
   correctDuplicateSubfields "690" "59"
   correctDuplicateFields "690"
end
```

Details

Title	**The ascent of Denali (Mount McKinley)** : a narrative of the first complete **ascent** of the highest peak in North America
Creator	Stuck, Hudson, 1863-1920
Publisher	Lincoln : University of Nebraska Press
Creation Date	1989
Format	xix, 188 p., 34 leaves of plates : ill., maps ; 21 cm
Note	Reprint. Originally published: New York : Scribner, 1914 "A Bison book."
Subject	Stuck, Hudson, 1863-1920 -- Travel -- Alaska -- **McKinley, Mount** Mountaineering -- Alaska -- **McKinley, Mount** **McKinley, Mount** (Alaska) Denali, **Mount** (Alaska)
Source	Library Catalog

https://unl.primo.exlibrisgroup.com/permalink/01UON_LINC/4occt9/alma9910112245197063 87

Challenges: Community Zone (CZ)

We are unable to change existing metadata in records sourced from the Alma CZ

- Normalization rules can supplement CZ records with preferred subject headings
- Subjects are added in a local subject field (690)
- LCSH are hidden from display using DEI exclude list in instances of direct 1:1 changes

650	_0 |a Gender identity
650	_0 |a Sexual minorities
650	_0 |a Sexual orientation
690	__ |a LGBTQIA2S+ people |5 NbU

Details

Title	**Gender Is Really Strange.**
Creator	Goetz, Teddy G., author.
Contributor	Standing, Sophie, illustrator.
Publisher	London : Jessica Kingsley Publishers
Creation Date	2023
Format	1 online resource (42 pages) text file rdaft
Subject	**Gender** identity Sexual orientation LGBTQIA2S+ people

Challenges: CDI Records

The only tool capable of impacting Central Discovery Index (CDI) records is Alma's DEI exclude list

- The DEI exclude list can remove and replace subject terms and add annotations to subjects in display
- It is limited in function and is only useful for direct 1:1 changes in CDI records
- Using it will apply to all records, not just CDI

Results

LCSH	Repaired subject heading
~~Illegal immigration~~	Undocumented immigration
~~Problem children~~	Children with behavioral problems
~~Sexual minorities~~	LGBTQIA2S+ people
McKinley, Mount (Alaska)	Denali, Mount (Alaska)
America, Gulf of	Mexico, Gulf of

Next Steps & Resources

Although the pilot project has finished, the work continues.

- A new group will convene to continue identifying problematic and replacement subject headings
- We are developing a submission form for users to let us know if they find a subject heading in need of reparative work
- We are maintaining a GitHub repository containing our normalization rules and workflows

Resources

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Thank you!



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